AFFIDAVIT OF MARCIA EVADNE WHITFIELD

In Support of Form I-360, Petition for Amerasian, Widow(er), or Special Immigrant

(VAWA Self-Petitioning Spouse of a U.S. Citizen)

A-Number: [A-NUMBER]

I, Marcia Evadne Whitfield, declare as follows:

About Me

1. My name is Marcia Evadne Whitfield. I was born on March 14, 1984, in Spanish Town, St. Catherine, Jamaica. I am a citizen of Jamaica. I live at 418 Prospect Street, Apartment 3B, East Orange, New Jersey 07017. My A-Number is [A-NUMBER].

2. I make this affidavit in support of my Form I-360 self-petition as the abused spouse of a United States citizen, Vernon Lloyd Lattimore. Everything I state here is based on my own personal knowledge. I read and understand English, which is my first language.

3. I came to the United States on August 2, 2018, in J-2 status as the dependent spouse of my first husband, who came here as a J-1 research scholar. I worked as a home health aide with the employment authorization I had as a J-2. My first marriage ended in divorce in June 2021 in Essex County, New Jersey. We simply grew apart, and the divorce was not contested. We had no children.

How I Met Vernon and Our Marriage

4. I met Vernon on Saturday, October 23, 2021, at a birthday gathering for my longtime friend Desmond Reid at Desmond's home in East Orange. Desmond and I have known each other for about twenty years, since we were young people in Spanish Town. Vernon was a friend of Desmond's from work, and Desmond introduced us that evening. Vernon was funny and very attentive. He asked for my number before he left.

5. Vernon and I began seeing each other in November 2021. We went to dinner, to the movies, and on long drives down the Shore. He came with me to church a few times and met my cousin Simone Barrett when she visited from Brooklyn for Christmas. He told me he wanted a wife and a real home. In March 2022 he asked me to marry him, and I said yes because I loved him and wanted to build a life with him.

6. We married on July 15, 2022, at East Orange City Hall. Desmond and Simone were there, and afterward we had a small dinner with about fifteen family members and friends. On the day of our wedding I moved into Vernon's apartment at 418 Prospect Street, Apartment 3B, and my name was added to the lease. We opened a joint bank account and shared all of our household bills.

7. In August 2022, Vernon filed a petition for me so that I could become a permanent resident, and I filed my application to adjust status at the same time. When we were preparing the papers, I asked Vernon to pick up certified copies of our marriage certificate from the city registrar. He came home with a certificate for a different couple. When I pointed it out, he became embarrassed and finally admitted that he could barely read. He had hidden this from me the whole time we were dating. I was hurt that he had kept such a big thing from me, but I told him it did not change how I felt and offered to help him. For the first year and a half of our marriage we were mostly happy.

How Vernon Changed

8. Vernon worked as a forklift operator at a distribution warehouse. In February 2024 he lost that job, but he did not tell me. For about three weeks he left the apartment every morning at the usual time as if he were going to work. In early March 2024, I ran into one of his coworkers at the supermarket, and he asked me how Vernon was doing since he was let go. I was shocked.

9. That evening I asked Vernon why he had lied to me. He jumped up, pointed his finger right in my face, and shouted that it was his business and not mine. He was so close and so loud that I backed into the kitchen counter. I had never seen him like that, and I was frightened.

10. After that, Vernon changed completely. He slept until noon or later and did not look for work. I was working long shifts as a home health aide, and he expected me to pay the rent and all the bills, and also to cook, clean, and do the laundry. If dinner was not ready when he wanted it, he would yell at me. He called my food "slop" and "garbage," pushed his plate away, and told me I could not do anything right. He called me "stupid," "useless," and "worthless," and other vulgar names that I am ashamed to repeat. He said no other man would ever want me.

11. Vernon began staying out late, and sometimes all night. In June 2024, after he had not come home or answered his phone for most of the night, I went looking for him at the house of his friend Marlon in Irvington. When I came to the door, Vernon came outside and screamed at me in front of his friends to stop embarrassing him and to stop tracking him down like a child. His friends were laughing. I drove home crying and humiliated.

12. During this time Vernon still demanded sex from me, even when I told him I was exhausted from work or did not want to. When I said no, he would get angry, sulk, and accuse me of being with someone else, so I gave in to avoid a fight. I believed he was seeing another woman, because he was out all night and hid his phone from me. I felt betrayed and degraded, and I was afraid he would give me a disease. I went to my doctor to be tested because I was so worried.

13. My cousin Simone and I talk by phone almost every Sunday. Many times during 2024 she heard Vernon in the background shouting at me and calling me names. She would ask me what was going on and tell me I did not deserve to be treated that way. I usually made excuses for him, because I was ashamed.

14. In August 2024, I noticed that $600 had been taken out of our joint account, which was money I had put aside for the rent. When I asked Vernon about it, he said he had lent it to a friend. I told him we could not afford that. He got in my face, cursed at me, and spat on me. The spit hit my face and my neck. I went into the bathroom and locked the door. I cannot describe how dirty and small that made me feel.

Money, Lies, and My Immigration Case

15. Vernon controlled our money even though he was not earning it. My paycheck went into our joint account, and he kept withdrawing cash and lending money to his friends while I was struggling to pay the rent and the light bill. In early 2025 we received a notice that our joint federal tax refund had been taken to pay an old debt of Vernon's that he had never told me about. When I asked him about it, he told me to mind my business and that it was "his name, his money."

16. Vernon knew how important my immigration case was to me, and he began to use it against me. When I complained about how he treated me, he would say that I needed him for my green card and that he could have me sent back to Jamaica whenever he wanted. Our adjustment interview was scheduled for April 2025. On the morning of the interview, Vernon refused to come. USCIS rescheduled the interview for later that month, and he again did not show up. He told me, "Why should I help you get your papers?"

17. On May 17, 2025, while I was at work, Vernon moved out of the apartment. He took the television and some of the furniture and withdrew most of the money left in our account. He has not answered my calls or messages since then. As far as I know, he is staying with friends. We are separated but we have not divorced. I have remained in the apartment and I am paying the rent on my own.

How This Has Affected Me

18. Living with Vernon's abuse has changed me. I used to be outgoing and active in my church. During 2024 and 2025 I withdrew from my friends and stopped going to church because I was ashamed and did not want anyone to see how unhappy I was. I have trouble sleeping, I cry often, and I lost my appetite and weight. I still jump when I hear a loud voice, and I feel nervous when I hear keys at the door, even though Vernon is gone.

19. I never called the police on Vernon. I was ashamed, and I did not think the police would care about yelling and name-calling. I was also afraid that calling the police would make things worse at home and might hurt my immigration case. In June 2025, my primary

care doctor referred me to a licensed clinical social worker, Mr. Gregory Hale, and I have been seeing him since then. Talking to him helped me understand that what Vernon did to me was abuse, and that it was not my fault.

Conclusion

20. I married Vernon because I loved him and wanted to spend my life with him, not to get immigration status. I lived with him as his wife from July 15, 2022, until May 17, 2025. I have never been arrested or charged with any crime in the United States or in any other country.

21. I respectfully ask that my self-petition be approved so that I can continue to rebuild my life safely in the United States.

I declare under penalty of perjury under the laws of the United States of America that the foregoing is true and correct to the best of my knowledge and belief.

Executed on October 20, 2025, in East Orange, New Jersey.

_____	October 20, 2025
Marcia Evadne Whitfield	Date